

Oxen

And for 8 oxen. And they remain.

Bulls

And for 1 bull that remained in the last account. And sent to Betchworth 1. And none remain.

Cows

And for 3 cows that remained in the last account. Of which in murrain 1 before calving. Sold 1 before calving. Sent to Betchworth 1 before calving. And none remain.

Hides

And for the hide of 1 cow received in murrain. And sold 1. And none remain.

From issue of the dairy nothing this year.

Hens

And for 10 cocks and hens owing from 'churchscot'. And all were sold as within.

From wine nothing here.

Verjuice

Nothing here.⁴⁰¹

Utensils

And for 2 casks, 6 vats, 6 mattocks, 1 tripod, and 1 tripod bought, of which 1 is worn out, 3 tine casks, 1 iron-tyred cart with all equipment, 1 bowl, 1 basket, 1 barrow, 2 troughs in the bakehouse that remained. And for 1 hoe and 2 shovels bought. And all remains.

Faggots

And for 1,000 faggots made from underwood. Of which sold 400. In expenses of the lord and other magnates 600. And none remain.

24. 17 April⁴⁰² to 29 September 1320

This account follows another vacancy in the bishopric, following the death of Bishop John Sandale, and is correspondingly short, if complex. For example, the tenants paid rent for the whole year because of the dates on which payment fell, though 'churchscot' was not taken at Christmas 'because of the time of the vacancy'; no 'fines, levies, and perquisites' were raised through the manorial court, either. On the demesne, rye, beans, and oats were recorded as issuing from the grange in the following account

⁴⁰¹ In margin: 'Memorandum that it is accounted in the future year for 43 gallons of verjuice'.

⁴⁰² Bishop John Sandale died on 2 November 1319, just over a month after the beginning of the financial year 1319/20; his successor, Rigaud de Assier, was elected on 26 November 1319, though not consecrated until 16 November 1320. However, he received the temporalities from the king on 16 April 1320.

(see below, doc. 25): the rye was probably sown before the death of Bishop Sandale; the beans and oats must have been sown during the vacancy, as no spring-sown crops were planted during the period of this account. Nor is there any sign of the harvest of 1319 (which, all else being equal, would have been recorded in this account); since the manor lay in the hands of the king during the vacancy, this grain was presumably confiscated and probably sold. The information contained in the account is of interest chiefly because it covers another period of agricultural hardship: in 1319–20, nearly two-thirds of cattle in England and Wales were killed by a virulent outbreak of disease, probably rinderpest.⁴⁰³ Esher was not spared: in the account for 1318/19, 1 out of 8 demesne oxen died in murrain, a further 2 were sold 'for fear of death', and 1 more was sold because it was 'injured'.⁴⁰⁴ Although Esher tenants appear to have shown much resilience during the famine years, the cattle murrain may have proved a tipping point for them, for – on top of existing hardships – the loss of cattle would have deprived them of a source of dairy produce, meat, and manure as well as the means of ploughing. Indeed, in this account we see a considerable number of transfers of very small parcels of land: on each recorded occasion the amount of land transferred was between $\frac{1}{4}$ and 1 acre. Surviving cattle of any sort, especially oxen for ploughing, must have become highly sought after by desperate farmers, a state of affairs emphasised in this account by the purchase of six locks with bars for the demesne oxshed; indeed, the wall outside the 'great gate' was also repaired and buttressed, which hints not just at targeted rustling but at indiscriminate looting as well. The impact of cattle murrain is not the only notable aspect of this account, for we are also informed that the hall at Kingston, the rental income for which had collapsed, was being used by the sheriff of Surrey for storing wooden shingles that were destined for 'the great hall of Westminster'.

HRO, 11M59/B1/75, *rot* 10v.

Recognition fine

Gilbert Forestarius, reeve, renders account for 30s received from the recognition fine of the tenants there for the lord bishop, as fixed. Sum 30s.

Rent of assize

The same renders account for 10s 3d received from rent at the term of the Invention of the Cross [3 May]. And for [1]10s 4½d received from rent at the term of Michaelmas. Sum £6 7½d.

Increment of rent

And for 2d from Richard Walerond for 1 acre of land which he had by the surrender of Richard le Rotour. And for 4d from Richard le Fort for one plot of land called Aldhay which he had by the surrender of Thomas Sewyne. And for 1d from Peter Tebaud for $\frac{1}{2}$ acre⁴⁰⁵ of land which he had by the surrender of Richard le Rotour.

⁴⁰³ Slavin, 'Great Bovine Pestilence', pp. 1240, 1242.

⁴⁰⁴ HRO, 11M59/B1/74.

⁴⁰⁵ In MS, '*una diā acra*': this has been translated as 'one half of an acre' rather than 'one acre and a half' as the word order for the latter is usually different. The same applies to the other entry for Peter Tebaud, below.

And for 1d from Richard Walrond for one parcel of meadow containing 1 rood which he had by the surrender of William de Wexford. And for 2d from Peter Thebaud for one plot of land at Cleybrugge containing $\frac{1}{2}$ acre of land which he had by the surrender of Roger le Fort. And for 1d from the aforesaid Peter for $\frac{1}{2}$ acre of land which he had by the surrender of Legarda atte Hulle. And for 1d from Hugh de Wynteror for 1 acre of land which he had by the surrender of John atte Barr. And for 1d from William Sewyne for 1 acre of land which he had by the surrender of Roger Sewyne. And for 1d from John atte Mulle for one hedged enclosure⁴⁰⁶ containing 1 rood of land which he had by the surrender of John atte Barr. Sum 14d. Sum of rent with increment £6 21 $\frac{1}{2}$ d.

Acquittances and defects

Of which in acquittance of the reeve for 1 virgate of land for half a year 18d. Likewise in defect for a certain house and land pertaining to the church drawn into demesne 20s. Likewise in defect for 1 rood of meadow formerly of Legarda atte Hulle in La Brodemed drawn into demesne 1d. In defect for 1 rood of meadow of Albreda atte Hulle drawn into demesne 1d. Sum of acquittances and defects 21s 8d.

Sum of rent remaining 100s 1 $\frac{1}{2}$ d.

Rent of the hall of Kingston

The same answers for 2s received from the hall of Kingston and not more because it was occupied by the sheriff of Surrey for the use of the lord king for putting shingles⁴⁰⁷ there for the great hall of Westminster. Sum 2s.

Issue of the manor

The same answers for 13s 4d received from all pasture at Northwode sold, by view of the bailiff. And for 8d received from the fishery there sold. And for 3s received from pasture at Esher in Dounwode. And for 12d received from pasture in Bulbecompe sold. And for 8d received from pasture in Hullemed sold. And for 6d received from pasture in La Frith sold. From pasture in La Mour, Churgrave, Crumbe nothing this year because no buyer came. And for 16d received from pasture of the garden sold. From cocks and hens nothing because of the time of the vacancy. From pasture in the warren nothing because it was sown. And for 40s from hay of the manor sold to the lord. Sum 60s 6d.

Foreign receipts

The same answers for 40s from Arnold Polygrim, by tally. And for 13s 4d received from Lord William de Swaneton for the needs of the manor, without tally. Sum 53s 4d.

From fines, levies, and perquisites nothing because he had extracted none.

⁴⁰⁶ In MS, '*haya*', which can simply mean a hedge but can also imply an area of land enclosed with a hedge.

⁴⁰⁷ Thin oblongs, often of wood, for covering the roof or the side of buildings.

Sales at the audit

The same renders account for 11d from things sold at the audit. Sum 11d.

Sum of all receipts £12 6s 10½d.

Mending buildings

The same accounts for the enlargement of a certain room of the oxshed, as in a carpenter, inclusively, 3s. Likewise in one roofer with his boy hired for two days to roof the same building 8d, taking for a day 4d. In 100 laths bought for the same 5d. In 300 nails bought for the same 3d. Likewise in six locks bought with bars for the same 18d, price of a lock 3d. In one carpenter hired for two days for repairing and buttressing two walls outside the great gate 6d, taking for a day 3d. In roofing the same with straw 6d. In one roofer with his boy hired for one day to roof on the grange at Northwode 6d.⁴⁰⁸

Purchase of corn

The same accounts for 7 bushels of rye bought for the needs of the manor 3s 6d, price of a bushel 6d. Likewise in 1 quarter 7 bushels of barley bought for payments 6s 3d, price of a bushel 5d. Sum 9s 9d.

Weeding and mowing

The same accounts for the expenses of the lord's customary tenants for mowing the meadow called La Brodemed: bread from stock; in 1 wether bought for an accompaniment for the same by custom 12d; in cheese bought 3d. In the meadow at Esher named Hullemed mowed by piecework, with the meadow of La Lake next to Crumbe, and the meadow of Legarda atte Hulle, containing in all 3 acres, 18d, for an acre 6d. In spreading, turning, and pitching all the hay 6d. For the carriage of hay from La Brodemed: bread from stock; in herrings bought 4d. Likewise in mowing and pitching one piece of meadow at Northwode by piecework containing 2½ acres 15d. In weeding all the demesne corn at Esher and at Northwode 6d. In the carriage of 3 acres of hay at Esher and 2½ acres at Northwode 6d. Sum 5s 10d.

Harvest

The same accounts for the expenses of one boonwork of 22 men who reaped and bound all the demesne corn at Esher, for two meals in a day: bread from stock; in 132 herrings bought for an accompaniment for the same 13d, price of a hundred 10d, and each had in a day three herrings at noon and three at dinner; in cheese bought for the same 4d. In candles for the whole of harvest 1d. In reaping 3 acres of oats at Northwode by piecework 15d, for an acre 5d. In expenses of the reeve for harvest 2s. In carriage of all the demesne corn at Esher and Northwode 12d. Sum 5s 9d.

Stipend

In stipend of one hayward for the aforesaid time 3s. Sum 3s.

⁴⁰⁸ No sum is given.

Payment of rent

The same accounts in payment to the abbot of Chertsey for the land of Northwode at the feast of St Michael 6s. And in two ploughshares bought for payment to the same 18d. Sum 7s 6d.

Foreign expenses

The same accounts for the expenses of Richard Clerk, bailiff there, for his coming 2s 11d, by tally against the same. Sum 2s 11d.

Sum of all expenses 40s 7d.

And he owes £10 6s 3½d.

Rye

The same answers for 7 bushels of rye received from purchase as within. Of which in expenses of the lord's customary tenants mowing the demesne meadows and carrying hay ½ quarter by custom. In expenses of one boonwork 2 bushels by custom. Sold at the audit 1 bushel for 6d. Sum as above. And it equals.

Barley

The same answers for 1 quarter 7 bushels of barley bought for payments. Sum 1 quarter 7 bushels. And in payment of one hayward, who was hayward and carter from the fifth day of May until the feast of St Michael for 21 weeks, 1 quarter 6 bushels, taking a quarter for 12 weeks. Sold at the audit 1 bushel for 5d. And it equals.

From stock nothing this year.

25. c. 29 September 1320 to c. 29 September 1321

This account contains a wealth of unusual detail and brilliantly conveys the cumulative impact of the agrarian crisis of 1315–22. The effects of the cattle murrain are highlighted again, this time explicitly referring to the tenants' lack of draught animals. Nor was there any let up in the weather, for the hall at Kingston had recently been unroofed, perhaps as a result of the severe storms that wrought havoc elsewhere during the winter of 1320–21.⁴⁰⁹ We are left in no doubt about the impact of such conditions on demesne cultivation at Esher. Only 54 acres of land were sown, with no winter-sown crops at all being planted; this may well have been due to flooding, for very little land at Northwode was sown and oats, which are better able to withstand wet conditions, made up 94 per cent of the sown area. Although the impact on tenant livelihoods cannot be assessed with the same precision, two extraordinary details suggest that normal expectations of social behaviour were under intense pressure at this time: first, the bailiff was sent to deal with 'various men', apparently from outside the manor (although this does not necessarily mean they were from beyond Esher's boundaries), who were allegedly intent on inflicting damage and destruction on the bishop's property; secondly, presumably with manorial tenants in mind, the bailiff instructed a carpenter to construct a pillory, a cucking stool, and some stocks.

⁴⁰⁹ Kingston, *Climate and weather*, p. 224.